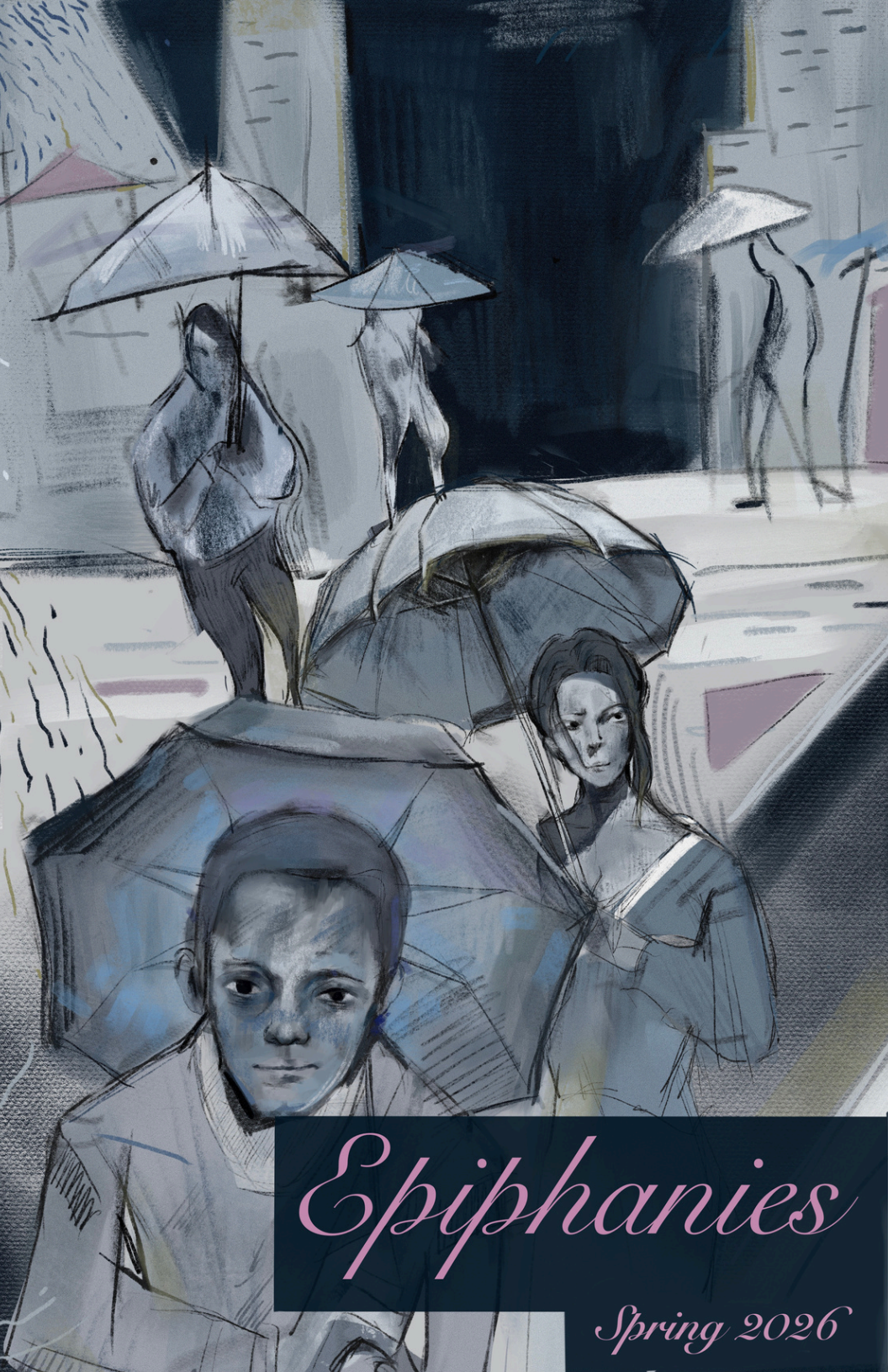




Epiphanies

Spring 2026

Epiphanies Literary Magazine

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Fleeting Seasons

Ella Ma '29

Soft rain on green grass,
Pink tulips drink in the sun,
Blue jays in the trees.

Hot sun in blue sky,
Waves warm Hawaii's white sand,
Mint ice melts so fast.

Gold maple leaves fall,
Cool wind moves through quiet streets,
Days grow short and calm.

Snow covers the road,
Frosty air fills the silent night,
Sparks glow in the dark.

Self Portrait as Ice Cream Flavors

Angela Feng '28

Caramel

My entire childhood tasted like caramel. Nothing was sweeter than that sweetness. If you've ever had caramel ice cream with caramel chunks, you know the feeling: first the sugar and milk, then the deeper sweetness when you bite into the caramel itself. The chewing, the lingering taste. I was satisfied. Completely. I had my first caramel ice cream in New Zealand when I was around six. After a long walk by the sea, I came back sweaty and tired, sat on a swing, looked out at the landscape, and took my first scoop. Caramel was there. My entire childhood was there. That exact sweetness, that exact feeling, I have never tasted again. Never.

Coffee

The first lesson I learned in life tasted like coffee. Not completely bitter, but different. I learned the difference between a latte and an Americano. Häagen-Dazs coffee ice cream became my favorite because it was sweet without being overwhelming. At the time, I only wanted sweetness in my life. I couldn't accept obstacles. I couldn't allow mistakes.

Coffee ice cream taught me something else. Even though coffee is known for bitterness, it doesn't have to be. I chose it because it was coffee transformed—adjusted and more acceptable. Over time, I learned to accept imperfection, and eventually, bitterness too. When I eat coffee ice cream, I feel grown up. It lets me pretend I'm older than I am because, in my perception, coffee is for adults. But the truth is, I'm still the kid who enjoys ice cream. As I grew, my taste changed. I no longer craved extreme sweetness. Coffee became neutral. Balanced. Enough.

Mint chocolate

After puberty, my taste changed, just as I did. I started to always choose the less-sugar option in everything—bubble tea, drinks, desserts. Mint chocolate became my first choice whenever ice cream was an option. The first bite is always sharp and cold. Mint stings before it refreshes. Then the chocolate arrives with its sweet, steady, comforting taste. Mint chocolate reminds me that effort comes before reward. If you accept the sting and

keep going, sweetness follows. But if you only want the chocolate without the work, you're left with the cold.

Pistachio

If I could choose a flavor for the rest of my life, it would be pistachio. Green until the end. Pistachio isn't very sweet if it is a nut. I don't even like nuts. Pistachio is the only one I accept. I didn't try pistachio ice cream until I was fifteen. I'm sixteen now. That says something about me. I didn't like trying new things when I was younger. I tried pistachio only because my mom liked it and I was curious. Once I realized it was good, I stayed with it.

If I find something I like, I keep choosing it. Again and again. Until I'm ready for a new try.

Flavors change as people change.

Some tastes disappear.

Some return.

Some stay.



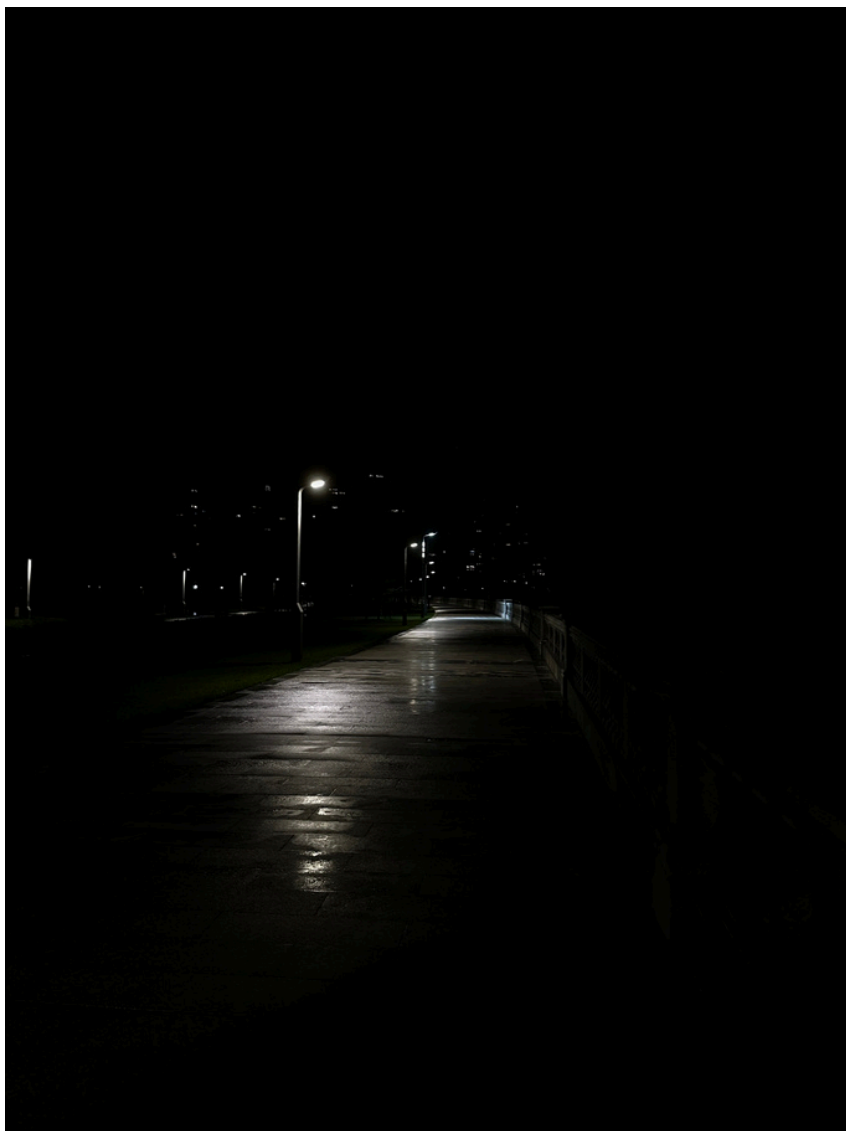
The Prayer Flag - Yulong Snow Moutain

William Wang '26

Freedom

Melissa Wang '26

He is the rarest bird in the world,
His shiny plumage was like the gems,
His eyes are sharp and bright.
The ornate outfit,
The gullible fool,
Which made him leave his beloved nest,
And be put in a cage made of gold.
He misses his home,
When he stayed in the cage of gold.
Although he craves to fly in the world,
He still lives with shackles for a long time.
His sapphire beak finally beat a hole in the cage of gold,
He's fanatic about his fate,
That ultimately rid the cage of gold.
The pretentious bird flies in the chilly sky,
Then, the bird falls down quickly and can't fly,
Hunters put down their guns and say contemptuously:
The valuable stuff should be kept in a cage; otherwise, it will be useless.
Freedom?
Free, damn.



The Night Watch

Daisy Zhuang '27

Modern Politics?

Tiantong Hu '26

A decapitation strike
is still too modern a kind of war.

Now you can no longer say
that war is simply
a farmer's son
killing another farmer's son.



Tyler, The Creator

Zoe Crowe '28

Silence

Griffin Richards '29

As the lights dim, the conductor slowly raises his baton, establishing the position to begin the piece. In this split-second, the theater is completely silent. I stand alone backstage, secluded from the rest of the orchestra by what seems to be a thousand miles, holding my silver horn in a death-like grip, but even its shining surface seems to be dull. Out of this moment of quiet, whispers start to echo all around me, blending together into a continuous stream, their haunting words cascading over me. The unintelligible murmurs continue to build, growing into a chant-like rhythm that ebbs and flows with every breath I take. Over and over again, I play my solo in my head, but each time it is tainted by a crack, breaking the music's delicate line. Then, the whispers begin to distinguish themselves, each one a fragment:

failure..

Silence..darkness..everyone listening..redemption..anxiety..doubt..flawed..
mistake..imperfection.. again.

crack..

The darkness all around me continues to become more and more complete, a curtain drawing to a close between me and the rest of the world. Then, I suddenly hear a single note cut through the noise, and out of the darkness I witness a brilliant light, a calming force emerging from the obscurity. It continues to grow, casting away the remnants of the shadow. As the whispers die away, I find my mind startlingly clear and empty of thought altogether. Until, in the presence of this light, I feel an impression upon my mind, not words, but deeply understood. It soon departs from my mind, leaving behind not an absence, but a feeling of peace throughout my body and soul. The baton descends.

Overwhelming Music

Olivia Hansen '29

My body shakes with anticipation as I tie my skates in the locker room. My mother comes in. "Ana, come on. You're coming up soon. I want you to watch the other girls." She looks frustrated that she has to come in and tell me. "Okay," I say quietly. She stands behind me as I lean on the thick plexiglass, watching a girl older than me land her jump on a shaky foot. "I've been keeping up with the deductions, and the highest scores are around your average from last year." Her voice sounds expectant, as if she's telling me to win like it's a chore. Instead of giving me hope, a pit grows in my stomach, as if there's a watermelon seed sprouting, threatening to grow out of my mouth. "I think you can win if you get your double salchow under control." She adds.

Before I can blink, the girl before me comes and goes, and it's my turn. It feels like a thousand years as I stand in the center of the rink, holding my entry pose. My body moves before my mind as my song blasts through the grainy speakers. As I skate, the ice screams under the pressure of my blade. My breathing slows as I pull myself into a spin. My body stretches, my heart and mind like the eye of a hurricane as I lift my leg up to my shoulder for a Y spin. Adrenaline rushes through my body as I push through my backward crossovers. I step forward to start my salchow. The entry is muscle memory, but as I lift my foot to push off my toe pick, I feel a rivet in the ice. My toe pick doesn't catch, and I can feel the lack of momentum as I still launch in the air. I pull my ankles together, preparing to spin, but I don't. I do one rotation before my spin abruptly comes to an end. I don't have time mid-air to reach my foot out for a landing before I crash to the ground. Crack. At first, all I feel is the cold surface of the ice surrounding me. Then comes the blistering pain of my body aching, and most vividly, my ankle. My limp body lies on the ice as I muster the energy to push my upper body up. I glance down at my ankle and wince at the unnatural direction it's pointing. The music plays louder than ever in the background as I try to pull myself onto my back to sit up.

The music cuts when I reach down to hold my swelling ankle as tears roll down my cheeks. People with vests and first aid kits come running but my visions blurry. I'm being carried off the ice on a stretcher as someone

unties my skates to release the pressure. For a moment, I'm almost relieved I'm not on the ice anymore. It's over, I'm not winning but it's over. I'm tired, and all I can think about is how much my ankle hurts. My mother stands over top of me, telling me that the ambulance is on its way. It's only 7:00 am and I just want to go to sleep.



Mountain

Mary Chen '27

February 7th

Logan Luo '26

I started hating to sleep,
maybe the night is dark and deep
As I close my eyes
My body turns dark with the room around me.

It turns out that cold has a color,
Dissolving me into this little room.
I am ice in February.

What proves my existence is that old heating panel,
That is my groan under extreme tension.

Each slow, gentle cycle of water flow
was a lingering warmth from an old, wild woman
Like a struggle,
So weak and fragile.

It was a lingering warmth,
A faint, struggling warmth,
Before it could reach my heart
It was diluted by the inky darkness
Leaving no trace of its presence.

In this little room,
The sound of lingering warmth becomes that of absurdity
Perhaps in this lasting coldness,
I, as a piece of ice, stained black,
Relying on an old object
To resist being completely frozen.

Before dawn,
It is a small piece of evidence of something called "life."

I no longer crave warmth given as charity.
The roaring sound still proves that
I am a block of ice with a heartbeat;
It's an old woman telling me,
I am the son of nature.

At least before dawn
I have not yet come to a standstill.



A Dual Existence: Yamamba
Cindy Han '27

Along The Riverside

Alice Allen-Harvey '29

finagling my phone out of my pocket, I quickly tuck it flush against my book. Hoping to myself that Miss Potts doesn't catch on as she reads Shakespeare as though he is in this very classroom. Looking up to see if she saw my inattentiveness goes good because she is still locked in with her Romeo and Juliet. Opening snapchat, I see my boyfriend, who normally takes 20 minutes to respond has granted me with the gift of a quick response. Debating to be peaty or not, I cave and open his text,

ok yes we should totally do that.

Really? I think it'll be fun but I can't risk falling of again.

dont worry babe, ill help you out again if you need. im always here for you.

I love you

...

He stops texting back.

Looking up again, only this time she is standing over me with more disappointment than should be legal. My eyes roam the walls during my walk to the principal's office, following each crack with intention. I find myself here a lot, which is quite unfortunate because I genuinely like my principal. Sometimes when I think too hard I get upset at myself for being such a hindrance in her life. But, there are a lot of things I actively choose to do and this is not one of them.

Her familiar smile drops as I walk through the door, I hope one day to make her smile. Alas today will not be that day. She is already ringing my father as I sit down in the maroon chairs directly across from her. Her office is quite nice for a public school, bookcases tower over behind her with forgotten details on the ceiling. I shoot my head down from my favorite spot of the crown molding as she starts to speak,

"Yes she is back. No I don't know what she did, hold on. What did you do this time, Livy?"

"I was only on my phone in English." I explain with little remorse.

She moves her decorated hand over the microphone of her phone.

"You know that that is not allowed, when will you realize that you have

so much potential?" No one has ever cared for me as she does, in a way it is like my mom is lecturing me. Back she goes to speaking with my dad, this is what I hear from her side,

"I know I know, I'm not going to give her detention this time but please talk some sense into her Robert." She cuts the line after saying a quick goodbye.

"I *am* sorry you know that, right?" I speak these words quite often, only sometimes earnestly. "No I don't. Just go wait in the hall for your father." She signs as though the phone call killed her cat. But I understand, it is not like I am naive to the fact this affects people. Just that I can't fix myself overnight, as much as I want to.

"Okay."

Walking out of the principal's office almost every day never gets easier, but this time it feels like more. The weight on my shoulders is heavier than normal, it is bothersome and painful. There comes this uneasy feeling of third person over me, as though I'm being judged for my worth. Nothing good is all I gather before sitting down and doom scrolling through Instagram.

My father walks through the doors, nodding to the security guard as though they are best friends. "Common kiddo, let's go." is all he says to me.

In the car he is clearly upset, or at least disappointed, but doesn't say anything. I put my airpod in while watching the forest speed by on the roads. I remember when I was a kid and used to stick my head out, or my hand. Playing with the wind before I knew what oxygen even was. Before I knew that those years of freedom and fun would come to an end as soon as they came.

Screech...

The car comes to an unsteady stop as we pull into the driveway. It is only noon, so I gather that my dad will probably be off in the garage or in his own world. As I'm thinking about what my dad is gonna do, I gather my things and hope out of the truck. The struggle of holding things and closing this big door never gets easier, I just deal.

"Dinner will be ready around 8, but I'm gonna go hangout with Trevor for a little while and I'll be back around 6."

"Okay, I'll see you soon dad."

Now I close the door, walking away fumbling for my keys and I, embarrassingly, drop them. I can picture my dad laughing at me as he pulls out of the driveway, which makes me laugh. Dropping my stuff on my floor I jump into my bed and feel the weight come back. I pushed the pressure off during the car ride but as soon as I start to think it comes back. I find myself contemplating my actions of the day, what lead to these feelings? Was it my choice of breakfast or just me getting caught texting him?

Forcing myself up, I look around my room with more intention than I have before. Feeling the sun creep away from my skin as it retreats back to the window. I have always been intrigued by that third person feeling I get sometimes, as I experienced earlier. At times I play into it as an escape from my own reality. These thoughts have been compelling me recently, why would I want to escape what I have tried to build? I find myself unfilled with the way in which my life has played out even though I can do everything to change it.

With these positive thoughts I make my way to the kitchen. Our house is pretty new, and it has a deck that overlooks a drop into the forest. When we first bought the house I was much younger, and therefore liked being outside. I used to go out there and just breathe the sappy air for hours. Making up stories about each insect and the leaves blowing in the wind. These memories still fill me with joy, how was I so content with nothingness?

Thinking about this, I wander to the sliding door which leads to my deck. The resistance of opening it illustrates how long it has been since anyone used the deck. Stepping out, the breeze hits me with a harsh whip. I find myself recoiling from the air, but continue on with determination. Tiptoeing with only my socks to the railing dodging the leaves, which could have bugs on them. Tipping myself over the board that spans on the railing top, I breathe as though it is my first time. In only a moment, I can feel my heart beating. I am alive, like genuinely alive, not having to view my life as a spectator but I can actually do something with it. I am in my own mind, in my own body.

Self reflection has always been an interesting concept to me, because it is a thing that requires no outside force. Unlike most things, you can do whatever you want within the scope of your own mind. Think whatever

you want, and no one will know. Such thoughts lead me back to my room, and return with shoes on the deck. I go down the back stairs, which are falling apart. The ledge that my house sits on is very steep, which is why I basically slide down it. I like to think I am falling gracefully, but in actuality I probably look stupid.

Far out in the woods behind our house lies a river, one which I haven't explored until now. After wondering for a while, I place myself on a rock near the river. Reaching into my pocket, pulling only one airpod out. I put on my playlist, and lay back on the moss. The rock is carved out so the arch of my back meets it, almost feeling like a hug. Hesitantly, I put my head back too so I am fully embraced by the environment. My music starts to pick up, and I calm down. My breathing slows, and I begin to lose control over my limbs. There is no resistance on my part when I doze off. Alone by the riverside.

As I look over myself, there are no more disappointed looks, buzzing phone, no weight, no internal or external forces. The water washes me clean, and with the current goes my soul. I am content with the forever rest.



Prayer in Solitude

Oliver Daughenbaugh '27

Oh, Baby Girl

Mari Zakarian '29

The larger surface of your palm interacts with the small infant's, her tiny fingers wrapping around one of your own with a feathery giggle that could soften your eyelids, lighter than a cloud, than a boat on the waves of the sea, and you couldn't help but respond with one as well. She's the light of your dimmed life in this isolated village in the depths of Artsakh, a province of Armenia. The horrors your people witness for centuries and to come is too much to smudge into one page, not to mention, the absence of your husband caused by the ordinance that men have to attend the army, but in the presence of your baby girl, the apprehensions seem to fade into the dimmed background you stand in.

Your cooing voice echoes throughout the empty compartment of your house, bending over the table and pressing your forehead against her microscopic one, the feeling of skin to skin leaving a longing feeling churning with pangs straight to your stomach. You miss him, with all your heart, you do. He doesn't deserve to spend nights in barracks and eat the junk food that they serve. He should come home from work and eat your homemade tolma, manti, khash, lahmajo, maybe even some pakhlava on the side. The months you've been alone, your only thoughts were of him. "Don't fret", he would tell you, "I will always come back".

And today is the day he will fulfill his promise. That he will come back. Back into your arms, back into the warmth of their domestic home, back into the bed you share, and back into your life again. In your daughter's life, one he has not yet gained the opportunity to meet, but when you show up to the military homecoming with your baby girl in your arms and see the toothy grin on his face, it will all be worth it.

The amount of food you prepared for his arrival was immense, the plates barely being able to fit on the wooden table. Aromas of spices and flavors of different kinds of categories filled your nostrils with such delight, the giddiness energizing your body through each and every vein. Your baby girl seemed to have noticed the excitement that radiated from her mother, the sound of her giggles mixed with the smells swirling across the room only fueling your exhilaration even further with a widening smile plastered on your face.

You frantically move around the small construction of your house, tidying up the leftover objects scattered around and wiping every little drop of dust that lies on the surfaces. Sweeping the floors, yelling to the neighbors and the whole village for the soldiers' arrival, it's all just a big event waiting to burst in the faces of all the men coming back. The other wives and sisters who are also awaiting their loved one's arrival smile in response, which you give one back as well. You couldn't help it. The villagers are finally gaining back the relief of tension they deserve and the feeling of the weight lift from their shoulders.

You walk down the pathway alongside the women of your village, holding your baby girl close to your chest with anticipation for the reunion coming up. She wasn't given a name yet, as you want to decide one with your husband. You imagine how he would wrap his arms around your torso and whisper the name that felt most drawn to him, a name you would not hesitate to place on her document if it makes him happy. If he's happy, you're happy. The women of your village have been looking forward to this day just as much as you have, even going over to the gardens together and picking fresh fruit to place in a basket, a signature way of expressing the depth of your love to another. The radiation of the excitement was brighter than the sun itself, and it was going to get even more intense once you all arrived at the standpoint.

There are crowds of families huddling up in their own designated areas, waiting to see the faces that they only see in their dreams for months. You stood right in the middle, eyes drifting from person to person as you clutched onto the small infant in your arms. The sound of the train railings staggering across the metal made everyone's ears perk up, shouts of excitement and happiness overflowing the compartment as people went straight to the line where the train would stop, pushing you out of the way until your vision wasn't the best from your perspective. The doors opened, the General speaking in triumph despite their many losses, as the civilians yelled in union, strength radiating from each and every individual. That is the symbol of your people. Strength and resilience.

Your arms are practically shivering in exhilaration as your eyes dart through every part of the train, armies of men swarming out of the doors and melting into the arms of their mothers, fathers, sisters, brothers, wives,

children, grandparents, aunts, uncles, even the neighbors next door, but there were also the families who stayed to the side who wait for their soldier to arrive. Their beautiful soldier, who was then deemed deceased from the General himself. It was absolute chaos, cries of both sorrow and joy, and you were tied between the two sides, still in the middle, waiting for your own soldier to arrive. The sounds were blocked out from your ears, eyes set on the only place they should be, the door.

The amount of men who were exiting had gradually decreased, which made your heart pound in your chest, but this time, not in excitement. Your hands tremble involuntarily from the sheer thought of... no, you can't think like that. He was going to come back, he was going to come back, he was going to come back, the saying continues to race around your mind until the very last soldier hops down the stairs and the doors shut. The doors shut. The doors shut, and the train creates a whistling sound to signal its departure.

Your hands went numb and flared open. You couldn't feel anything except the last string of hope barely hanging on while your eyes snapped from one corner to the other, maybe catch a glance of the single string of his hair in the crowd. No matter where you look, there wasn't any sight of him. No one could ever be him. The blood-curdling, gut-wrenching scream left your lips before you could keep it stuffed in the tightness of your throat, eyes widened and blood shot to showcase the insanity that overflows your veins. You were so caught up in the moment that you didn't notice the cracking sound of your baby's head dropping to the pavement, blood pooling beneath your shoes.



A Gathering in Paint
Cindy Han '27

Deaf and Blind till Death and Time

Mari Zakarian '29

Where'd all the time go? Back when we met as kids? The outsiders laid on the sidelines throughout years of school? The weirdos who met when there was no one else? I held her hand, although it felt colder than usual. I never really understood her, but I understood her. I couldn't see her. I haven't seen her since the day I met her. But I know that she is the most radiant, dashing, dazzling, picturesque living being to walk on the outer layer of Earth. If humans were to walk in the inner layers, her radiance would be too strong for any harm to be done to her. How I hate the universe for gifting me the poor offering of blindness. I can't see her. I want to see her. I've wanted to see her since the day I met her in the classroom. I remember that day as if it were yesterday. But it wasn't yesterday. More like over 70 years ago. I couldn't write my ABCs, so I stared blankly at the sheet of paper that I couldn't see. Then I felt a presence, writing for me. People always assumed that because I'm blind, I couldn't feel. But I felt her. I felt her. And she felt me. We were compatible from the start to the finish; the finish has still yet to come, but when it does come, I hope it takes me first. I hope it takes me first so I wouldn't have to go through the mourning of an unbearable life without her by my side, rocking back and forth in a chair, and I wouldn't be able to feel her rocking in synchronization.

A couple of years ago, she was diagnosed with amyotrophic lateral sclerosis, a nervous system disease that weakens muscles and impacts physical function. She has been hospitalized ever since, and her room has practically become my second home. For five years, I've been coming in the morning, exactly at 10:17, when she wakes up, to talk to her, small taps on the stomach. Since she lost the ability to speak and I can't see sign language, we use Morse code by tapping a part of our bodies that we can feel, and it works, but she didn't seem to respond so quickly. The disease doesn't allow her to think critically like she normally does, and given our ages, she probably feels too exhausted to answer back. That's okay. I'll wait. I'll wait like I always did. I'll wait for her like I did on the school bench in second grade when she handed me a flower that I felt was a daisy. I'll wait for her like I did in eighth grade, when she asked to meet in the classroom to learn morse code together. I'll wait for her like I did in eleventh grade when she

told me she'd bring her artwork that she made during scenic arts design, which was her sarcastic humor coming through since I obviously couldn't see. If it were anyone else, I'd be pissed. But it was her. I couldn't be mad at her. "The Blind Husband with his Deaf Wife", they said with mockery. Our whole lives, we were mocked, but she didn't hear. She was in her own little world while I listened to all the malarkey given from people who haven't experienced what I have. Love. I didn't need to listen to them; in fact, I didn't need to listen to anyone, not when I had her by my side. The only voice I'd listen to was her humming. She couldn't listen to songs so she made her own melodies. My favorite song was her melodies, the melodies I couldn't hear anymore because of this illness.

I held her hand tighter while continuing Morse code taps on her blanket-covered stomach, telling her the exact same thing I tell her every single day, reciting her favorite poem, "The Buried Life" by Matthew Arnold. She might have loved the poem more than she loved me, but anything she loved, I loved with the equal amount of power. I recited the poem over and over again, and it didn't matter how long the poem was. I had to keep myself distracted from the tears rolling down my cheeks as I heard the straight ringing of the cardiac monitor and the nurses shuffling and murmuring with concerns, trying to bring her back. The finish line has come, but she won the race before I could. Now, I sit there, the loser, crying on the sidelines yet again.



Senbon Torii Gates

William Wang '26



Rainy Fireworks

Daisy Zhuang '27

Morning Shower

Saige Biddison '28

Bleary eyes grasp knob
Scalding water spurts then streams
Tingling my scalp

Warmth trickles through me
Finally jolted awake
A shiver shakes me

I wring out my hair
Comb my fingers through tangles
Droplets smack the tub

Swirling suds sucked down
Burping through the hollow drain
Milky water gone



Soft Gaze

Peter Li '28

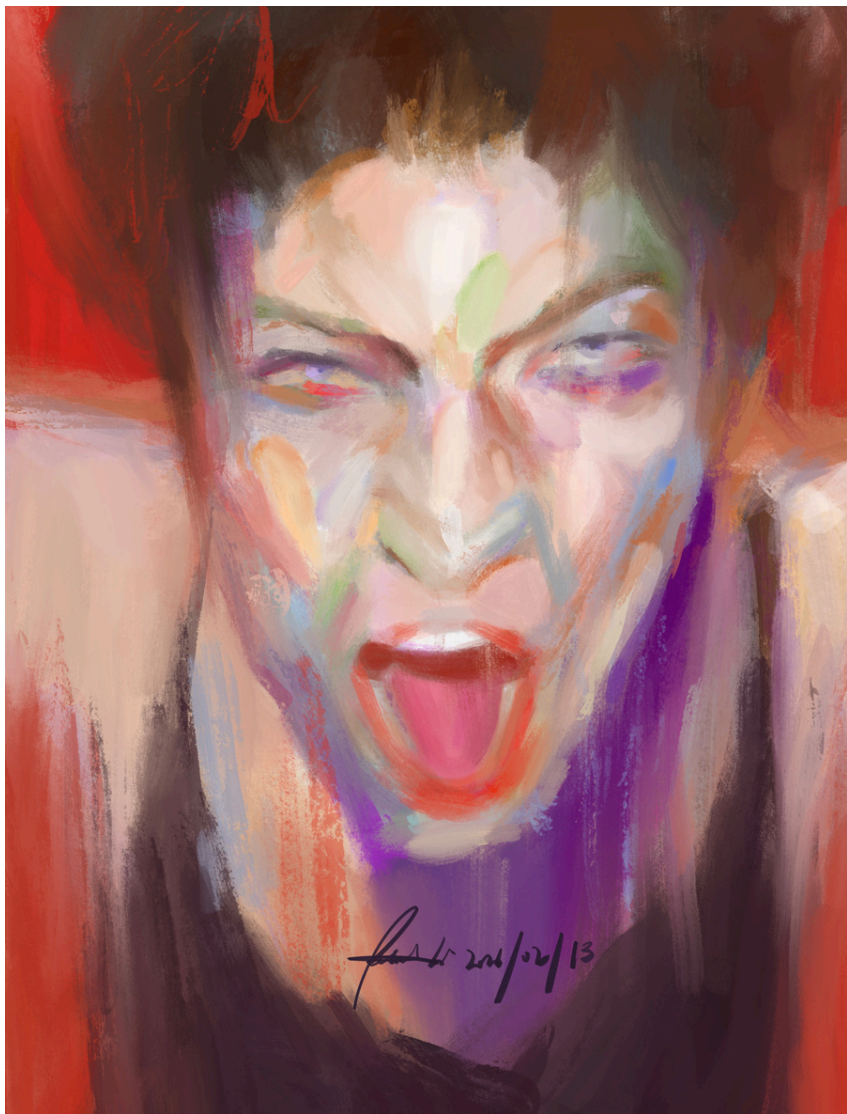
The Blue Giant

Sebastian Solis Cruz '27

Only five percent of the ocean explored,
Masses of creatures remain undiscovered.
Every new sighting becomes a reward,
So much to be uncovered.

Like the gossip that runs around,
The truth will never be found.
Too much to unveil,
Even NASA had to bail.

Yet given the unknown
Beauty cloaks it all.
Like a cover to be blown,
The curtain is yet to fall.



Scream

Peter Li '28

Kunsttriebe

Tiantong Hu '26

Imagine
the first love poem written by someone
who has never been in love
with the longing accumulated for decades,
combines one's ultimate imagination
of love, beautified by literature and art.
First love is like a revolution:
Youths mount the barricades,
wave high their bright banner.
Until—
Intoxicated, disordered,
thrilled, unified,
almost keeling,
reaching the peak of ecstasy.
Passion, chaos, the pulsing desire for art
*Dionysische Kunsttriebe.*¹

I saw a lamb standing, as though it had been slain.²
"She's a passion stronger than a chain
that torments my soul and doesn't let me live."
Danaë in the brass tower, simply she was.
Words of yearning flowing
from the spinning record:
"I seek after you,
I seek after you like the air,
I need you in order to live."³

Footnotes:

1. Nietzsche's *The Birth of Tragedy* defines the Dionysian as ecstatic intoxication and the Apollonian as orderly, dream-like harmony.
2. *Revelation* 5:6 (English Standard Version).
3. Fusco, Enzo. Lyrics from the song "Dicitencello Vuje (Just Say I Love Her)".

Then have my lips the sin that they have took.⁴
Make my lips bleed
I want to stay in this faintness of blue forever
My repeated whispers drowned out
by the soft rustling of plum leaves:
"I am yours!"

In vain,
I stretched out my arms towards her
when I woke up from my weary slumbers.
Yet the innocent dream had happily deceived me,
leaving only dissipating mists of exhilaration.
Beautiful things are difficult after all.
Charlotte, oh Varvara, oh, my Grisette
How did I fall so deeply in love with you?
Oh flesh, my own flesh, woman whom I loved and lost⁵
To whom should I address my letters?
To whom should I send these epistles?
My darling—my darling—my life and my bride.⁶
To whom should I apply these names of endearment?
Where, too, could I find you?
I love you as I love the light of God.

"In three days I shall be shot
by the soldiers of God."
Radiguet had uttered before his death.
Will I, too, be shot by His soldiers?
When Voltaire wrote the poem
under the bright oil lamp,
did he see that short Russian
climbing that mountain alone?
Even Tolstoy believes in God.

Footnotes:

4. Shakespeare, William. *Romco and Juliet* 1.5.119.

5. Neruda, Pablo. *The Song of Despair*.

6. Poe, Edgar. *Annabel Lee*.

Hoffnung!

前进！前进！前进！

Razumov woke up shivering⁷
from the dream of walking
through drifts of snow in Russia,
as completely alone
as any betrayed autocrat could be.
He could see her enormous expanse
as if she were a map—
an immense, wintry nation.

Его Россия.

Его *родина*.

And why would I, who loves my country
who have nothing but that to love and believe
to have my future, perhaps my usefulness,
ruined by this murderous fanatic?

Yet, I am still on the way to the lighthouse.
like the menstrual blood discharged by my motherland
dripping on the soil
on the withered violets
My desperate body left your infinite tenderness,
whatever awaits me in the future—
death or a new life—
all alike, I am going to meet
with an ecstatic welcome.
Away from this dictator
democracy, cult, the welfare of all people in the world
are all for me to worry about;
This land, this lover beneath me, this nation.
This woman who has nurtured me with her own lactation.
This goddess who has scolded my uncleanness.
I love so deeply yet detest—

Footnotes:

7. Character from Joseph Conrad's novel *Under Western Eyes*.

this woman who becomes one with me.
Myself.

My soul still languished for this unattainable happiness
but you have already begun to abhor me
You moral men are so tamed and oppressed!
Pass by, like the Levite
and thank God, like the Pharisees,
that you are not like me.

Have you no sense of decency?
That nightingale pressed her heart to the thorn
for the creation of love from death
for the crimson rose for us.
I want to see you burn.
Where is your dignity as a reed that thinks? ⁸
I need to kill that leopard
right in front of you.
Peel it,
dig its heart out 'cause that's your heart,
press your hand into its ribs.
The gurgling sound will be the sound of my blood!

I want to gouge you!
Just like how Michelangelo gouged out his Madonna,
how the swallow gouged out the prince's eyeballs!
You will make me bleed
because every drop of your blood makes me thirsty.
I will empty the fountain of your blood,
and turn the Sahara into the Red Sea, and drown Moses.
I have his scepter!
I want to stab myself.

Footnotes:

8. Pascal, Blaise. *Pensées*.

"Could it be that you ate from the tree that I commanded you not to eat from?"

"The serpent deceived me, and I ate." ⁹

Then dismantle me, reconstruct me

Press the tip of your knife to my flesh—

I will write poems with my blood

I will write poems with my marrow and body fluid

and I will bite it into you

Letter by letter.

I will give you the flower

I will give you the key to my kingdom of heaven

and I will give you her lying dead body in the long grass—

Don't say a word!

I am your knife and butcher

I am your snake and the fruit of the knowledge of good and evil

I am your lamb and castrato

I will fight you away from all the days, from all the nights

From all the swords, all the flags of golden shine

From Him whom Jacob wrestled beside the ford

For the land is my cradle, the land is where I'll end

For the entire world is your cradle, the whole world is where you'll die! ¹⁰

The weapon of criticism cannot, of course, replace criticism by weapons. ¹¹

At least now I know

My feelings toward her

is not the feeling Young Werther had for his Charlotte

nor the feeling Narcissus had when he saw himself in the lake

No.

I, too, am superfluous.

Footnotes:

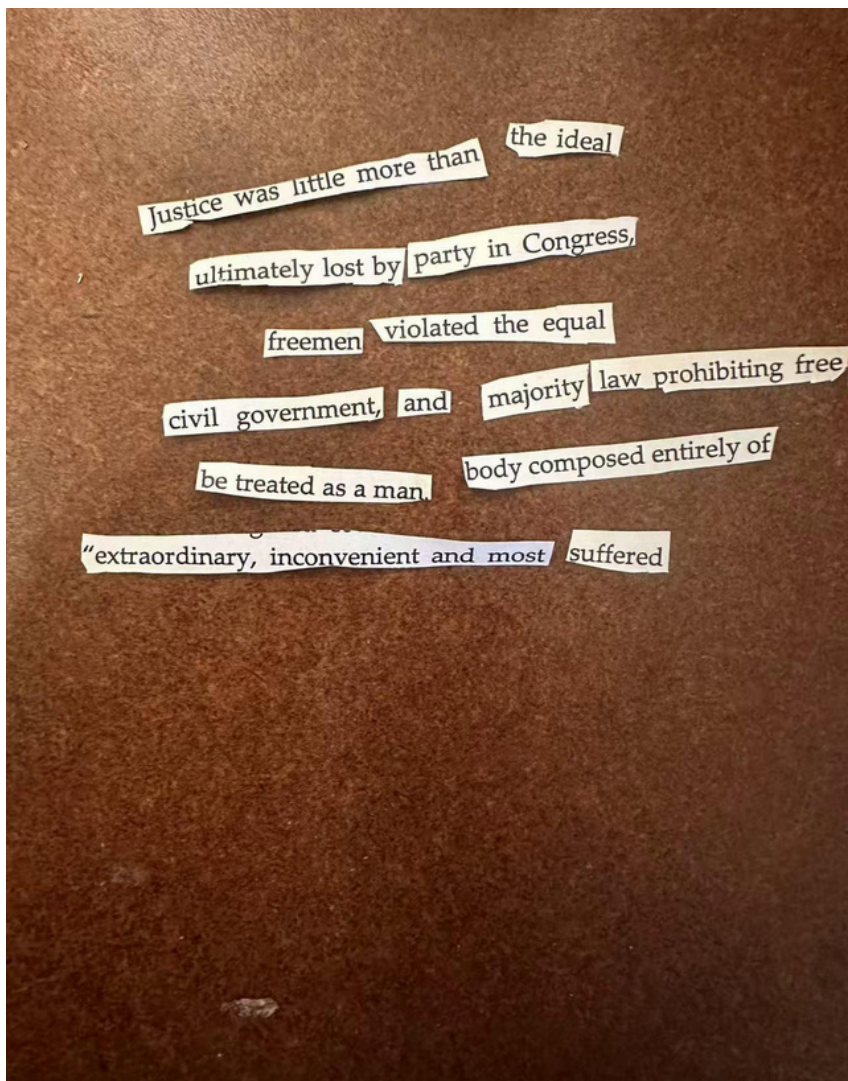
9. *Genesis 3:11-13* (New International Version).

10. Tsvetaeva, Marina. *I will fight you away from every sky, from every land*.

11. Marx, Karl. *Critique of Hegel's Philosophy of Right*.

It is just a vague dream
of getting rid of myself,
at least eliminating one surplus existence.
But even my death would be unnecessary.
My corpse, my blood
on these stones, among these plants, in the depths of this smiling park,
would be unnecessary.
My decaying flesh would be excess in the soil.
My bones, washed and decontaminated,
finally as clean and fresh as teeth
would also be excess.
I would rather be Prometheus
forever my liver being eaten
yet having the hope of being saved by Heracles one day
My eternity is redundant.

I don't want to be the king of Egypt
filling my carcass with spices to seek immortality.
Nor do I want to be a slave in the pyramid
spending a lifetime building an enormous city of death.
I just want to be a casual wanderer
in this moment of sunset, in this tender dusk
Look at the frivolous happiness on people's faces in the bar
Look at the ripples of daydream golden by the dusk
Look at women's indulgent smiles and charming dresses swaying in the
wind
I'll breathe the air
losing my bones and mind, merely living within my own flesh
Apollonische Kunsttriebe.



Collage Poetry

Melissa Wang '26



Foggy Rain

Alina Jiang '29

1950 America

Kit Shi '28

1950 is the cinderella year
The waiting is over!
But did you see and hear
The climax and the boom

Yes, we have reached the end of the yellow brick road
As now,
America stands at the summit of the world
An era of satisfaction and promising prosperity
Cars, Airplanes and vacuum

Suburbs, television and "Baby Boom"
For sure
This is the Golden Age



Ad Inferum *Cindy Han '27*

Perditi animi permissionem Charonis quaesunt transcendere ad Inferum.

Chornobyl is not what it seems...

Morrison Anderson '29

I should never have gone.

When my friend Dmitri suggested that we explore Chornobyl, I sarcastically said yes. I thought he was joking. But then he said, "No, I'm serious." That's when we started packing. We brought essentials, food, water, flashlights, a medical kit, a fire starter, Geiger counters, flares, and sleeping bags. We made a plan to sneak in around 4 in the morning, which worked easily. We started walking through the woods near the city, and we mostly hung around the border of the two. We decided that the next day, we would explore the forest, and the day after that, we would traverse the city.

After making our way around the border and finding a spot that had minimal radiation picked up by our Geiger counters, it was already dusk. We set up camp, and I volunteered to go look for firewood. While it took me little time to find some good logs, I couldn't ignore this feeling that, not only were we not ever supposed to be here, but that we were not alone and being watched. I brought back the firewood, and we used our fire to warm some water for tea and dry our boots.

That night, I had a dream, no, a nightmare. I was being chased through the woods, with pine trees that reached the bottom of the clouds. This... Creature was chasing me. It was humanoid-shaped, but not human. It was tall, around 3 meters at the top of its head. Its arms reached down all the way to its kneecaps, with skin that was as pale as the moon. But the most terrifying part was its face. It was as if someone had taken their face and replaced it with skin, but the skin is stretched, creating a smooth, polished surface where their mouth, eyes, and nose should be. That was the face, or lack of it.

I woke up as the sun was peeking through the trees in the morning, drenched in my own sweat. I wish, oh I wished, that we had left after that. But Dmitri said that since we were already here, we might as well finish our journey. We packed up everything, making sure we left no trace we were there, and hiked deeper into the woods. We kept seeing things that didn't make sense, like colossal gashes in the trees and scraps of fabric. As the severity and the frequency of all this increased, a bunker came into view,

blast doors sealed shut, and the sequence of NOVA-23 was written in giant block letters on the door.

Out of curiosity and our little to no amount of fear, we broke through a partially buried maintenance door on the opposite side of the bunker. The door led to a ladder, so we climbed down to the first of 3 levels. On the first level, it appeared to be, or at least used to be, the sleeping quarters of the structure. But it looked as if a herd of sentient sawblades had run through it. There was dried blood everywhere, and nearly all the cots had either been gashed open or strewn across the room. Then we noticed the bullets.

The bullets were floating in the air, as if someone had frozen them in place. On the far wall, we noticed something written, and when we read it, I think that it was when we knew that we were not where we should be. The writing, made and splashed in blood, said *Omnes in facie mortis cadent, et dii in facie exitii contremebunt*. Then we went down to floor two.

This floor appeared to be some sort of armory or supply room, as guns were scattered across the floor and air, with some floating like the bullets in the floor above. There was no blood, but there were other things. Floating military uniforms, looking as if someone had been running away from something they were terrified of, and they disappeared, leaving their clothes stuck in the air where they were.

Then, instead of blood on the ground, there was this... liquid.

I don't even know how to describe how it looked, but it looked similar to obsidian, but made into a gel. The same writing was seen here as well, but we counted maybe 8 times it was written on this floor, written with the black liquid that was everywhere. Then we finally descended to the bottom.

This floor was the one most dilapidated, with chairs and desks thrown about, walls that looked like someone had lodged an explosive in them, and long, deep gashes in the walls. There was even more of the fluid and writing on this floor, with the writing overlapping one another, and it was written with claw marks. We also saw lab coats, similar to the uniforms, floating in the air. As we walked farther into the darkness, barely illuminated by our flashlights, I noticed an office that looked like it was the head of this operation.

We walked in, and found a journal on the desk, most of the pages

ripped out, and the only legible entry from April 26, 1986. It said this: "We were able to create a duplicate of the morphine using the control rods, but it had changed a bit in the process. We injected it into a volunteer soldier. That's when hell began. I need to activate the STARFALL failsafe, and..... TO THOSE WHO READ THIS: NEVER ENTER SITE NOVA -23. WHAT WAS CREATED CAN NOT ESCA- *Omnes in facie mortis cadent, et dii in facie exitii contremebunt, Omnes in facie mortis cadent, et dii in facie exitii contremebunt.* We then realized we needed to get out of here now. But as we made our way back to the ladder, running at Mach 5, Dmitri's steps stopped behind me.

I turned around, and what I saw was not my friend anymore. His eyes were pitch black, leaking the same liquid that was on the ground. His jaw contorted, stretching all the way to his waist, with circular rows of needle-like teeth. His fingers were three times as long and sharpened into points at the end. Then I saw them, more creatures that looked just like Dmitri, but in lab coats and military uniforms, and behind them all, the creature from my dreams. It was as if it commanded them. It let out a shriek like the sound of glass scratching, and I ran, climbed the ladder, left all my gear except my phone, bolted out of the bunker, and ran out of Chornobyl. I never looked back, knowing my friend was gone, turned into that monster.

As I reached an area with cell reception, my phone had a seizure, with an unknown number texting "DO NOT GO INTO THE BUNKER. WHAT WAS SEALED INSIDE WAS NEVER MEANT TO BE RELEASED," over and over again. I am sending this to the web. Because I NEED someone to believe me, believe what I saw. And the world needs to know this: Chornobyl was not just a power plant, and the disaster was not an accident. It was a laboratory, and the disaster was a cover-up from what actually happened on April 26, 1986, meant to keep us from finding out what really lurks in the shadows of that city.

Omnes in facie mortis cadent, et dii in facie exitii contremebunt.

Omnes in facie mortis cadent, et dii in facie exitii contremebunt.

Omnes in facie mortis cadent, et dii in facie exitii contremebunt.

Omnes in facie mortis cadent, et dii in facie exitii contremebunt.

Omnes in facie mortis cadent, et dii in facie exitii
contremebunt.

Omnes in facie mortis cadent, et dii in facie exitii
contremebunt.

Omnes in facie mortis cadent, et dii in facie exitii
contremebunt.

Omnes in facie mortis cadent, et dii in facie exitii
contremebunt.



Coniunx Hospita *Cindy Han '27*
Coniunx hospita prophetatur a Phoebō.

Yesterday's Tomorrows

Zimo Li '27

Today shall be the last day of my life. I've lived for 30 years as a competent component of the society I'm in, and it was not so delightful to be part of. Gladly, I will be able to witness the sky above us. I will be on the moon for the first time in our history. After that, I will be euthanized; some more competent component will be replacing me. I don't regret my life; I hope it will end well.

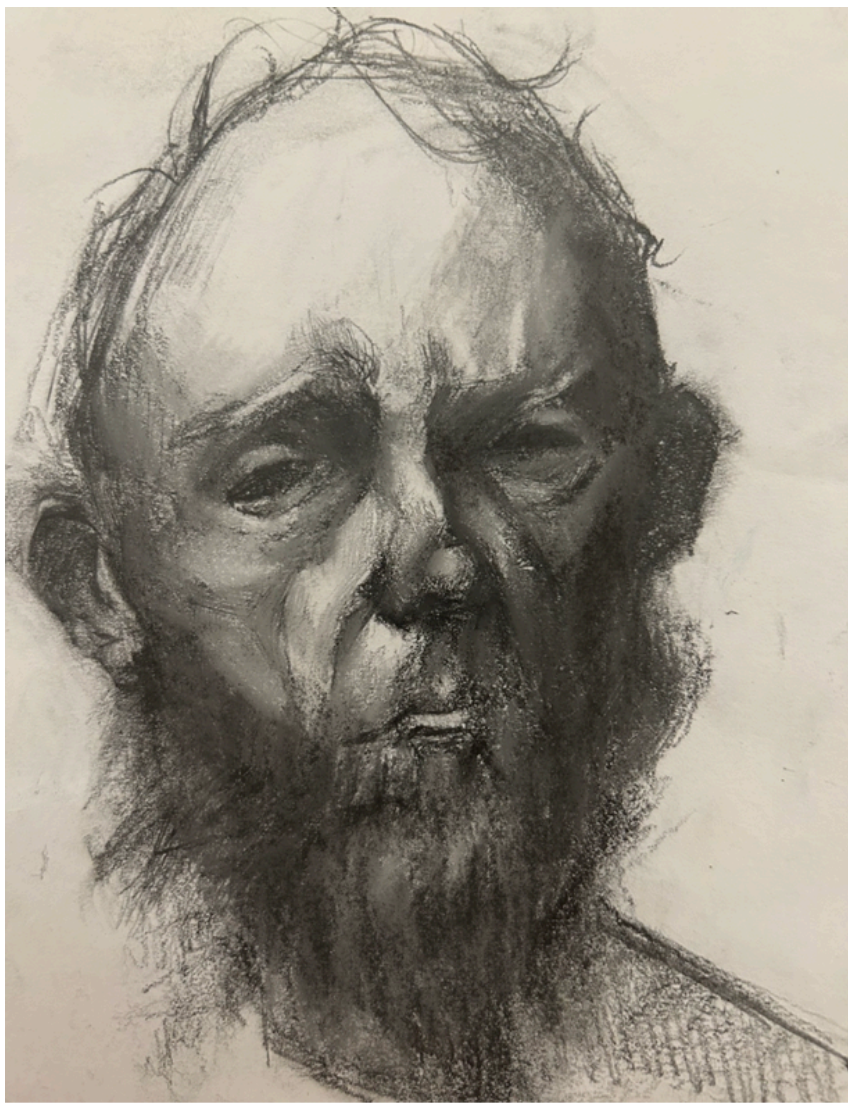
Everyone was excited, the rocket launched, we penetrated the sky and reached space. Then we landed on the moon as the mission was scheduled. Everything was fine, except that we saw a piece of cloth. It was so dim that time had wiped away its color; it was so bright that I could barely see anything else from how it shone. It was a golden disk. Next to it, there was a flag.

Any competent individuals were vanquished, and the others knew they were witnessing the end of history. I looked at the sky, seeing the black planets approaching us. They hovered above the sky and dropped a few bright points. Those points exploded in the atmosphere, turning the impact area into a fiery red ocean. The ocean soon flooded the other parts of the sky, revealing the true image of the deep, dark sky beyond our knowledge. And there are more of them. Our tiny, pitiful planet, for the first time, became the focus of the universe. It was a hope for every mankind ever existed, and it came true today. I fell to the ground. My eyes were shaking, my face was cramping, recalling every moment in my life. At the very last second before I lost consciousness, my lungs exhausted all the air, and a weird angle twisted the end of my lips.

I was surprised that I could still open my eyes. I tried to close them, but my body insisted on living. I tried to move my limbs, but they disappeared. I gradually moved my eye to a piece of reflective glass, ready to embrace the very end of my life with a pathetic picture of my remains. However, I didn't see myself. I saw an oval-shaped, semi-fluid bag of flesh. I tried to look for myself in the image reflected in the glass, and the sole eye left on the bag moved with me. I slowly moved my eyes back and examined the image; the figure also moved back to examine me. I tried to kick the glass away; the

figure rolled around strenuously, ending up with dirt in its eye. I felt no dryness in my eye, but the warmth of the blood pumping in my veins. It burned my skin, like it shines in my body. All I could do was let my blood circulate faster and faster. I don't know how I moved, how I lived, I even lost the heart I could once feel within myself. Before my eye pumped out and my blood rushed from my corpse, I saw nothing on the ground and aligned myself with the dome, aiming the tip of the fountain, made from my own body, toward the hottest star in the sky. There was a red, dripping lotus.

After another thousand years, how should we describe the scenery we see now? Maybe that should be a question that we will be answering now. We were the first generation of humanized components. Some of our instructor societies criticized us, because we the societies are by us alone: each of us became a society. They say that it's not obeying the guidelines. Humans made the sky in this form, humans rediscovered history in this form, abandoning it will be the sin of our generation. I looked at my body: twisting limbs stretching out of my original body, circular eyes placed at the center of my face, everything else cold and metallic. I was informed of these a long time ago, but it was the first time I heard the sound of my body. I saw my heart pumping fluid at a slow, steady pace. I took it out and felt its temperature in my hand. Its left side oscillated first, then its right side carried the wave to the rest of my body. It never stopped pumping as it glowed in my eyes. It never stops pumping as it glows in my eyes. It was the darkest metal ever observed on our planet, and because of that, it reflects the brightest light in my eyes.



Anguish

Peter Li '28

remember the ARMENIAN GENOCIDE !

Mari Zakarian '29

Oh, how the atmosphere gloomed when the "Armenian Genocide" was talked about.

How the twisted, snide comments were said, how the jokes and remarks kept pounding in my head, I was set.

I was set on the fact that they didn't care, I was set on the fact that I couldn't bear to stay in that room once more.

The room kept following me, following through the path I had to crumble myself just to escape from it but it followed.

Followed like it always did.

The truth that people don't know about the genocide, the even dreadful truth that they don't care enough to ask "Hey Mari, tell me more about the Armenian Genocide." It was forgotten.

The bloodshed my ancestors went through was forgotten.

The pain and suffering my great-grandmother endured both during and after the genocide was forgotten.

The stories of the millions of Armenians gone unnoticed.

Yet, the room still follows me wherever I go, waiting for the words "Armenian Genocide" to come out just so more snide comments can be made.

And we're back to the beginning.

The World's Last Breath

Mari Zakarian '29

Chaos. Destruction. Obliteration. All because of *you*. All because you wanted to shape the world into your image, but only to result in seeing the Earth change from the blue and green colors to the darkest shades of crimson and black. You could hear the screams of terror all the way from the spacecraft from the land, but the guilt was nowhere to be found. They deserved it, didn't they? Their naive little brains put all their trust into technology and thought that all their worries would dissolve into the midst, but life isn't that easy. You were the one who worked for everything, and you deserve all the rewards you can get. Not them. You've been planning this for months, waiting for the right time to eliminate the weak creatures who call themselves humans, manipulating the chip and taking control over land-based intercontinental ballistic missiles to start this very bloodshed. They were fighting in a nuclear war, they thought they started amongst themselves, but the real cause was watching them from above.

Looking down through the window and observing Earth go into the drop of doom, you kept a straight and stoic face before turning back to look at your beautiful creation, placed on the highest pedestal with protection all around it. The Neuralink, but your version. Being the newbie at the Neuralink company meant that no one was going to be taking you seriously. They thought you were ingenious, unsophisticated, uneducated, an idiot. It was hilarious, honestly, the very same people who laughed at you in the break room were the same ones drowning from the holocaust and the blaze.

As you picked up the chip, your eyes softened in awe. As if it was your own child. A child about to be placed in your brain. It was so glorious and majestic that you could potentially ignore the banging and yells of your co-workers, who were trapped across your room, trying to stop you, but they can't stop what the fate of the world will be. The Neuralink's initial purpose was to help the people who had absolutely no hope in this life, which didn't have a good weight on you. A better motive would be to give the strong more strength. To give the intellectual more intellect. To give the important more importance. You may have done a slight little twist to

the coding of the Neuralink, giving you the abilities that an average human being wouldn't have, to breathe a different kind of air than them. You weren't going to live in Outer Space your whole life, no way! A dignitary like you deserves the best of the best, and you could see the world in such a better place.

Before you know it, the chip is in your brain and your drop ship is on its way back down to the ground, the only thing on your mind being how your next generations of humans will be the greatest and most powerful in history. The thing that takes you out of your fantasies is the thump that signals your landing on Earth. Sure, you were nervous, but the anticipation and thrill outweighed any stress you had in your mind. As the drop ship opened, the view would be portrayed as an apocalypse or a sight of catastrophe, but for you, it was a sight for sore eyes. The grin was the last thing you felt before a huge pound onto your head leaves you falling to the ground. You thought you were alone, didn't you? How naive you were. Now the commoners are grinning. You're not the one in charge anymore.

Chicken Wing

Jerry Rao '27

Cooking and preparation—it's wing day!

Hot sauce—don't forget it!

I would also add buffalo.

Curate with diligent patience, crisp and clean

Key in the number I eat is the curated flavor.

Eagles game—TOUCHDOWN, see ya, Chiefs! –

Neverending savory spicy nibbles, I don't realize I've eaten 30.

When I finish the sticky sticky wings,

I wipe my hands with a paper towel. It's dry, but my hands still smell juicy; I–

Need to wash them clean.

Gone are they down the drain, forever.



Kabukicho, Shinjuku
William Wang '26

Wilting Rectangles

Angela Wang '26

1

Tiantong and I sat by the edge of the grass quad space, on the low stone wall that jutted out from the grass. Teacher Ellen, our English teacher, waved to us from the other side of the uneven circle. We were to read our poems that won Westtown's Jackson Denton's memorial award last year. His friends had set up a meeting for worship in his memory and invited the alum of '10.

"I never knew it was such a recent thing. The award," I had said as we walked down. "I thought they'd all be old and white-headed and y'know, like teacher Jonathan." Teacher Jonathan was a cordial Quakerism teacher who acted exactly like you would expect a vintage Quaker figurine would, if those even existed.

Trees brushed against the sky, fracturing it into angular polygons. The memorial event proceeded, with only a hiccup or two from the baby in the stroller. Dressed for the indoor AC temp, we perspired, read our poems, then perspired some more. Next it was the meeting for worship, as per Quaker tradition. The silence was held only briefly, a thin slip of paper between lips.

These thirty-year-olds, whom I did not previously know, rose one at a time and recounted tales of this mysterious Jackson, this Prospero that had broken his own staff, relinquished his so potent art of words and set his own spirit free.

He wore button-ups on the first day of school and always signed his full name.

He wrote his friends heartfelt letters and spoke at commencement.

He was an excellent actor. He ran in cross country. He went to Temple. He produced songs.

I felt like a cinematographer shooting the first take of a scene, panning in and out of these faces, parents and children, crying and smiling, the man rocking the baby stroller, the baby who continued to chew on his pacifier with a bovine tranquility. The May sun beat down on our backs, and I thought, there's a poem in this. Then proceeded to chide myself still thinking there's a poem in this when the collective pain laid bare before me, these half-ironed wrinkles of grief, was so tangible.

Later we sauntered back to the realm of festivities and ice cream so colorful they looked radioactive with Other Teacher Ellen. She was a middle-aged woman with puffed curly brown hair and a gaze so soft it ruled out the possibility of her teaching high school. If memory serves, she also wore a sprightly flowery shirt.

"Thanks for sticking around. So, what did you think?" She asked us.

We shared a smile. I can see the perspiration forming on your nose, Tiantong tells me. So do I, I respond.

"It reminds me of Theseus's ship," I say. "Like, if all the planks that made a ship were changed, is it still the same ship? If all the people who inhabit a place were gradually replaced, is it still the same place?"

"Well, personally I think I keep seeing the same kids coming in every year." Other Teacher Ellen shrugs. "You know, they're not the same kids but they're similar, and I know how to work with them."

"That makes sense." I skip across the crack on the cement. "But that might be because part of your job is knowing how to work with kids. Even so, it could be more of the placeness of the place itself than the people." Placeness. A word both sacred and unbearably empty.

Tasteless, tactless, all the words I could attach to -less wouldn't be enough to describe how much of a vacuum the situation felt like. We approach the intersection of paths. Other Teacher Ellen waves to another teacher waiting for her in a golf cart. Naturally we had to part.

"Thank you," we said in unison.

"Thank you," she said. I've never quite mastered the way teachers say it, it both politely terminates the conversation and shows the other person respect (because how does one respond? No, thank you more? That's just like pushing a red packet back and forth saying you don't want it when you visit a relative. Alas, I have not had that experience in three years, so who am I to make references to Chinese customs? Even the word Chinese sends chills down my back. Tiantong agrees that it's revolting).

We got tickets from the registration tent, joking that they were ration coupons in socialist communes, but then arrived in the queue just in time for the ice cream truck to drive away into the sunset except it wasn't sunset.

It was three in the afternoon, and I had to wake up from the daze cast by the spell of the sun, because nothing was going to alter the fact that I was being propelled forward by time. And so were Other Teacher Ellen and Tiantong. And so was Westtown. Regardless, the truck filled with the antidote to lethargy and heat and complacency left us with our hands empty save from a few useless words on wilting rectangles. The lemonade dispensers inside the main hall had already been emptied as well.

3

With a quick search and press of the enter key, I found a photo of him in a digital obituary. Despite almost everything being digitized, obituaries being digital is still quite unexpected for me—because I still associate the internet with connection and anonymity, never a named grave. Never an obituary. And death of a loved one was supposed to be private, a headstone that only you knew where to find among a terra cotta of thousands of others, that existed regardless whether the tab was open or not. Not an easily perishable webpage. Why was I getting upset over this?

The last part of his digital obituary read, "In lieu of flowers memorial contributions may be to the Jackson G. Denton III Fund for Creative Writing at Westtown School, 975 Westtown Road, West Chester, PA".

I would like poems rather than flowers at my grave. We used to burn paper money and paper clothes for my aunt, who drank pesticide on the day before new year's. How unceremonious, my grandma had commented. Idly I speculated how Jackson did it. Was it pills, hanging, noxious gas or as simple as the open, cold, nothingness of falling? It had to be poetic, I suppose.

I study the photo of him. A man with skin so pale and a smile so studently. So American, so distant. Realistically I knew I didn't care about Jackson. As in, I could imagine being in his class and never interacting with him aside from an occasional group project assigned by random. So what was it that was troubling me, on this clement summer day?

4

To be truthful, despite all the #community that Westtown touts itself as, I've never felt really connected to the community.

In sophomore year, back when I consumed horror like Wednesday morning bagels and worshiped Stephen King, I wrote a story about a kid getting eaten by the walls of the school, which turned out to be one sprawling macabre living body itself. I sold it to others as "my toxic relationship with Westtown."

Weirdly enough, the more you try to step away, the more a place swallows you.

5

I read somewhere that a poem is like an ambulance: when you're inside it, you know something's already wrong. How did he feel, lying inside the entrails of an enormous metal insect, whirring away from life's grasp at a velocity far too fast to comprehend? How did he feel lying in a casket woven by poems?

I suppose he wouldn't have felt anything, as his body was already cold by then. Probably cremated, for all I know. Yet—

"Jackson still lives on here, somewhere." A friend of his had stood up and said. *Somewhere. Here.*

The gathering was sutured together with words, words, and oh, so many words. Poetic justice, perhaps this was what Jackson wanted. Time stretched taffy-slow. *Did it even matter, whether I knew him in the first place?*

6

They tell us that a piece of writing has to have an epiphany of some sort. I told them poetry was just useless words on wilting rectangles you held in your hand as you watched the ice cream truck drive away.

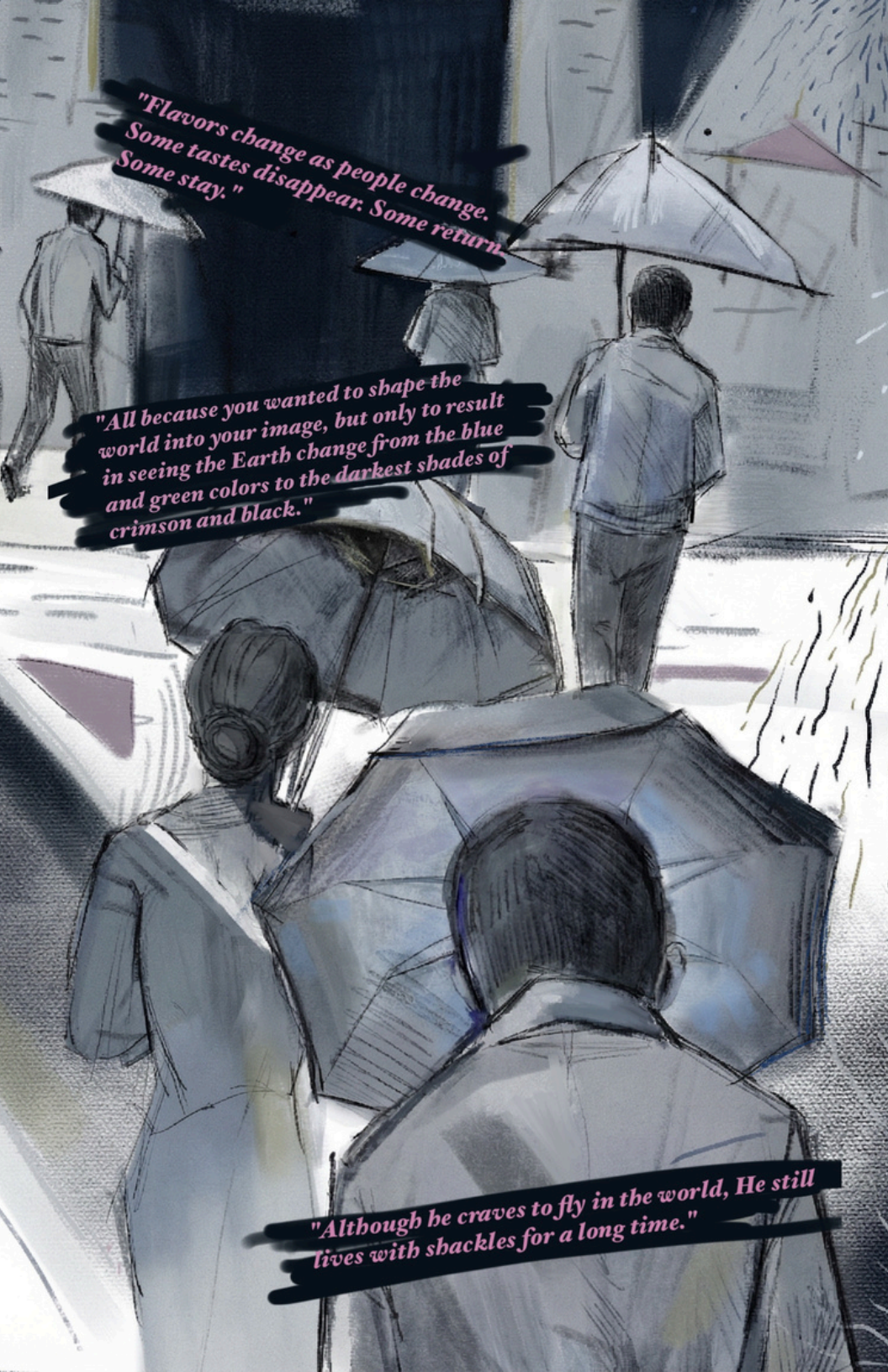
7

Later, watching Tiantong attempt to dismember an orange bare-handed, I get a call from a disoriented Melissa claiming teacher Ellen had knocked on her door and asked for our whereabouts. She found it quite peculiar because in our experience, teacher Ellen was a "day teacher" who only "spawned during school days in the main building."

We sprint upstairs to find teacher Ellen wearing her usual concerned expression. Something about wanting to "check in." I thought we didn't have to check in with our student IDs during lunch because it was alums weekend. *Beep*. Something like that. My brain was milk, and her sentences were the colorful cereal and lucky charms floating within it. A click of the heavy door and she was gone.

"She probably thought we were going to get all depressed and stuff. Like a poet would." Tiantong said as we walked back to our adjacent rooms.

"Yeah," I echoed, "Like a poet would."



*"Flavors change as people change.
Some tastes disappear. Some return
Some stay."*

*"All because you wanted to shape the
world into your image, but only to result
in seeing the Earth change from the blue
and green colors to the darkest shades of
crimson and black."*

*"Although he craves to fly in the world, He still
lives with shackles for a long time."*